while writing, Jaya insisted, ‘you cannot write a book on the BJP without writing about women’. She became my tutor on the world of gender studies and her refusal to take no for an answer forced me out of my usual comfort zone and turned what was originally a 500-word section into a 20,000-word chapter. Similarly, though I was reluctant to insert myself into the narrative and write about personal histories in the Introduction, she persisted for a week, simply refusing to relent until I finally agreed and wrote them in. Despite the lockdown, she also conducted the riveting auction with India’s top six publishers that led to this book being published. I have been lucky to have her as a partner in this project.

I am also deeply grateful to Rajneesh Chopra, of C&C Associates Advocates and Solicitors, who represents the book as a lawyer, and provided an all-encompassing legal covering brief after reading two drafts. Rajneesh’s friendship and immense belief and confidence in the project was hugely encouraging. His valuable advice helped keep out unnecessary howlers.

Finally, the magical and brilliant Karthika, my editor. She has literally chiselled every sentence, debated every word and argued over the nuance of meaning in every translation I put in. Karthika has always had my heart as an editor ever since she commissioned and published my first book over a decade ago. So, naturally, I was ecstatic when she pulled out all the stops to bag the auction for this one. I naively thought I had it all done already but putting the manuscript through the very special Karthika microscope and wringer streamlined and made it significantly better. I am never quite sure how she does it, while managing her entire stable and all the complex things she has to do as a publisher, but her deeply thoughtful and razor-sharp editing—across three line-edit versions—showed how much she truly believed in this book. An editor who respects the author’s voice (even when it strongly confronts her own), gets the larger point of it all and is willing to do whatever it takes to make a better product (while balancing editorial sanctity with commercials) is a dream to work with. Karthika is that rare publisher who does all this effortlessly: without showing her stress, without putting any pressure, and she is always open to a debate on even the smallest word and throwaway line in a footnote. Sonia Madan